



Visits of Foreign Counterparts

*"After one look at this planet, any visitor from outer space would say
'I want to see the manager.'"*

—William S. Burroughs

Now that we have outlined the etiquette to be followed when you are on a foreign visit, it is time to look at the other side of the coin, namely the visits of your foreign counterparts and other foreign stakeholders to your location. Such visits demand that you be a perfect host, who not only exceeds the expectations of your foreign visitors had about their trip, but also set the stage for a sustained, strong and special business relationship with them.

Such visits will typically involve knowledge transfer, project kick-off, review meetings, planning meetings and so on. The profile of people travelling will vary from very senior-level people who would typically visit for business discussions, strategy planning and review meetings to operational-level people who would visit for knowledge transfer and operational work. This chapter deals with the etiquette to be followed when such a foreign visitor comes to India. This covers the preparations to be made, what to do on the days of the visit, how to conduct the meetings with the visitors (over and above the generic meeting management principles discussed earlier), coming to closure on the items discussed and the post-visit follow-up. We conclude the chapter with a brief coverage of some cultural issues.

34.1 PREPARING FOR THE VISIT

Snapshot 34.1

Every once in a while your office might get into a high gear. New potted plants may suddenly appear along the otherwise drab hallways. The administrative assistant's 'cube' may get a makeover. And five star hotel rooms and luxury cabs will be reserved *en masse*. The boss would alternately cajole you into doing a few favours for him or yell at you for not doing something that was up to his expectation. It is announced folks, that the foreign client Mr Smith (whose project is one of the largest in your group's portfolio), is finally going to be in your campus for that much-anticipated business visit, accompanied by a six-member entourage. It would be emphasized that this client visit is 'most important' and that no stone should be left unturned to pull off a good meeting. (If your 'company' is an offshore unit of a MNC, then your foreign visitor could also be the top boss from your own headquarters. But, for the purposes of this chapter we will only talk about a foreign client visit).

There is always the danger of such visits as described in Snapshot 34.1 turning into poorly-managed, out-of-control, nightmare affairs, casting serious aspersions on your corporation's or location's abilities and status. However, a few simple, basic principles can turn these high-stress events into successful milestones that might not only strengthen your existing relationship with your client or your boss from HQ, but could also very well bring additional business to your location or company. The key to making the best out of such visits is to keep pressing on with the business agenda, while paying consummate attention to every detail of your guests' needs. While the agenda that you prepare would address the business needs of the visitor, it would be a good idea to check with the visitor whether he has any specific social or personal requests for which he may need help. For example, they may be interested in some weekend trips or may have some specific shopping to do. You might like to make provision for these, but don't impose yourself on the visitors.

34.1.1 Know Who the Visitors Are

The first step in planning how to handle a business visit is to find out who the visitors are. Even seasoned world-travellers may feel a bit odd at times in some foreign countries (and the visiting group might include some first timers to India) and may have special apprehensions and needs. Some of the things you may need to find out about them (without being nosy) to help you prepare for their stay are:

- ▶ Is this their first time in India?
- ▶ Did they get any not-so-pleasant experiences in India in their last visit?

- ▶ Do they have any special personal needs like medical, religious, food, mobility needs?
- ▶ Do they have any preferences for place of stay?
- ▶ Do they have time and do they like to take some weekend time off for sight seeing or shopping?
- ▶ Do any of your team members know anything more about any of the specific visitors? In particular, is there any tough nut among the visitors that you need to put special focus on?

Finding answers to these questions would put you in a better position to make the visitors more comfortable and put them in a better frame of mind for the actual business meeting that is indeed the purpose of their visit.

Many foreign business people visiting India are typically clients of Indian companies or line managers or senior managers from a parent organization abroad and therefore, are at the giving end of an unequal relationship. If this is the case, this will have to be factored in all of the preparations.

34.1.2 Preparing the Infrastructure for a Visit

Remember that first impressions are the best impressions. Also, in some quarters, there is a lot of negative baggage about India. It is important to not give opportunities for reaffirmation of such negative thoughts. Here are some tips to make sure your infrastructure preparations are going in the right direction:

- ▶ Make sure you have made appropriate arrangements for pick-up and drop-off, especially in case your visitors are coming to India for the first time and ensure that you have some English-speaking driver available to take them around.
- ▶ In case the visitors want to do any shopping or sightseeing, it would be great if the driver is an expert on the local shops and tourist spots. It is also okay for one of the local team members who knows the local conditions, to accompany them, should that be desired by the visitors and be acceptable to the team member.
- ▶ Make sure that you have back-up power supply to keep the meeting running uninterrupted and that all your audio and video equipment and other infrastructure are humming along fine.
- ▶ If the agenda calls for conference calls or video conference, then make sure that the right equipment is available. A conference room with video conference facility may need to be booked in advance.
- ▶ It is also a good idea to prepare for the availability of drinks like coffee and tea and not to assume that there is a one-size-fits-all coffee or tea. One must remember that some of them may drink coffee black and without sugar. Some people prefer 'regular' coffee and some may want decaffeinated coffee. So, don't pre-mix a concoction that you think of as 'coffee'. Have the basic components ready and give the visitors the flexibility to make their own drinks using what they want.

- ▶ What is called 'cool drinks' in India is often called 'soft drinks' in other places. Furthermore, some of the visitors are particular about 'diet' drinks and 'caffeine-free drinks'. Just make sure that the refrigerator is stocked with the various combinations.
- ▶ The visitors may want coffee or drinks 'on-demand', instead of the ceremonial, scheduled coffee breaks and therefore, have a pot brewing all the time and have easy access to the soft drinks. In business meetings in the USA, oftentimes you will be simply shown the coffeepot or the refrigerator and you are free to serve yourself at any time.
- ▶ Make sure that every one of your staff who is going to attend the meeting has his/her business card with their proper job titles, ready.
- ▶ Finally, (it might sound like a trivial exhortation) be sure your toilets are neatly maintained and easily accessible. In many countries, well-maintained workplace toilets are a given.

34.1.3 Preparations for the Business-side of the Visit

In parallel with the infrastructure arrangements, get started on preparing for the business end of the visit.

- ▶ Make an elaborate and all-encompassing agenda very much in advance. Get it okayed by your foreign counterparts. However, even if you get a formal okay, anticipate and plan for last minute changes. Flexibility is the name of the game.
- ▶ Gather the right personnel to cover the various items on your agenda. A visit by a foreign delegation is not a spectator sport to be witnessed by all your employees and so, be judicious about who needs to be present. Include only those people who are germane to the project or topic, but do have a few other support staff ready for contingencies.
- ▶ Find out if anybody else from your end or the visitors' side needs to join the meeting via telephone and make sure all arrangements are made for them.
- ▶ Assemble all the required data and make sure that the relevant team member has these on his fingertips. Think about various alternative scenarios, business proposals, negotiation points, negotiation postures and tactical re-orientation ideas and keep them handy in your back pocket.
- ▶ Your foreign visitors will be very interested in seeing things for themselves. So, make sure that you put on a show (a demo where needed) for them—your assembly lines, computer systems, communication lines and computer security systems—all should look and perform as advertised. The guest list, the agenda and the topics of discussion are all dynamic and could change right up to the last minute of planning. So be ready to accommodate a myriad requests and changes.

- ▶ Practise a couple of dry runs of mock meetings conjuring up all impossible scenarios and questions. If the visitors want to see data for the past three years, can that be arranged? If they want to meet that entry-level programmer who is working on their module (about whom they are very uncomfortable), can you take them to meet him?
- ▶ It helps to talk to your office-mates who may have dealt with some of the members of the client brigade previously.

34.2 THE ACTUAL VISIT

Finally, after weeks of planning, the appointed day arrives. Your visitors have been received at the airport, have been ushered into their hotel and already the foreign delegation is sending out positive vibes—unless of course, they managed to lose their luggage (after a five-hour plane delay) and someone had to work some magic to mollify the agitated visitors.

The foreign delegation troops into your office and it is time to execute.

34.2.1 Start of the Meeting

Whether you are a main presenter at the meeting or a support staff, it is important to pay attention to your get-up. An unwritten rule is that clothing should be neutral to conservative. Make sure that the formal clothes that you had mothballed away in a closet fit you on the day of the meeting and that you know exactly how to do the double knot on your tie. For women, a saree makes a wonderfully elegant formal dress. Of course, a western-style dress slack or dress is equally appropriate.

In the western world a handshake—the mundane act of squeezing your palm into the other person's hand and pumping it two or three times—is considered an anchor on which a future relationship will be built. No wonder this practice has been much analysed, dissected and sterilized into a fine art. People in India generally don't pay much attention to the mechanics of a handshake, although they readily indulge in it, sometimes even gratuitously.

Remember to grab the other person's hand firmly, shake it vigorously two or three times and then let go immediately afterwards. Limp handshakes and extended hand-holdings are a no-no. Look into the eyes of the person introduced. However unfamiliar their name is, try to register it and remember it. If you don't get it the first time, ask for their name again. A simple, universal, 'Hi, I am Ajay' or something similar is okay. Avoid saying 'Myself, Ajay' or even worse 'What is your *good* name?'

The protocol used to be that men did not shake a woman's hand, unless the woman offered it in the first place. But nowadays, with the decrease in gender differences in the business world, any hand is shake-worthy, man's or woman's, as long as it is a hand that does business. So women should not be too bashful about a sudden, unsolicited handshake from a male.



"I am Bernie Smith, the CZO of the company. We are still trying to figure out what the Z means....."

Fig. 34.1

The next step is to hand over your *business* card to them and get theirs in return¹. Although some cultures make a little ceremony out of this act—by holding the cards in both their hands and bowing slightly—a simple swap of cards in the most practical manner is okay in the Indo-US context. Make sure your business cards are not made of non-biodegradable plastic. If on the other hand, they are made of recyclable paper, you may win a few brownie points with your visitors for being environmentally friendly. Standard sized cards with standard job designation should suffice. If your card generically describes you as 'chief' or 'team leader', it does not convey much about your role in your company. Try to make sure that the job title indicates the role clearly.

Then at around the appointed hour, you seat yourselves—the more important persons in the pecking order taking the vantage positions—and usually the two delegations will sit across each other at the table. The support staff should sit at the back, away from the table.

You may not realize it, but your foreign visitor is scrutinizing every move of yours in the first ten minutes since you shook his hands. He is trying to ascribe meanings to your many, initial body movements, forming that all important first

¹ In India, business cards are called *visiting* cards and the use of this term leaves the foreign visitor flummoxed. Stick to the term business cards.

impression on which to hang his business dealings. A limp handshake might lead him conclude that you are quite a wimp and poor eye contact and nervousness might bolster his aggressiveness. In just the first ten or fifteen minutes, they may even have a fairly prejudiced opinion of who is good, who is not, who really matters and who is there just for the ride. Be aware that there are subtle undercurrents and that they always reference things back to the American or European sensibilities and then form opinions. Hence, put your best foot forward in the initial few minutes.

34.3 THE MEETINGS PROPER

The main meetings should proceed like clockwork. Time management is crucial and equally important is that complete ground is covered to the satisfaction of all parties, on all items on the agenda. If additional time is needed and cannot be provided right away, off-line meetings or extra presentations at the end of the meeting can be worked in. It is highly likely that you may have to depart from your carefully scripted presentation and may have to address some concerns of your visitor that you had not originally planned to discuss. Make sure you understand your visitor's questions and concerns and if you don't have a ready answer, either get it from someone who does have it or tell your guests that you need to research it further and will give it to them later and make sure you complete the loop later, as promised.

It is important to remember where you are horizontally and vertically in your organization and stick to the hierarchy and protocol during business meetings. Although you may be privy to a lot of information, if it is not your domain or function, it is extremely inappropriate for you to be talking about it. Don't steal other people's thunder and give other people's speeches. There will always be some information your boss might provide at his level (or the top management might discuss at their level) and here it is important that the tail does not wag the dog. Let the big boys and girls handle the mechanics of the meeting. (And if you are the big boy or girl, make sure you grab this ownership.) Your job must be to ensure that when you are called for your information or opinion, you give it clearly and to the point. If you don't understand your visitor's accent, ask him to repeat and likewise, if they don't understand your accent, repeat your utterance. If they still don't get it, try to form a different sentence to convey the same meaning. If a member of the delegation corrals you outside and demands some information—and you are not sure if this information can be passed on to him—guard your information and give it only after consulting with your boss. Don't do private favours to members of the visiting team. Likewise, don't give them the 'insider's view' about your company, however much you are prodded and made to talk.

Business meetings these days are reasonably informal. It is considered alright to go in and out of the meeting room, provided you don't disturb the proceedings with a splash entry. It is considered okay to carry your cell phones in your pockets (of course, in their silent or vibrate modes) so that you are still connected to the outside world. Make sure you don't have the phone ringing loudly especially with the fancy musical filmy ringtones. If you do get a call, step outside the conference room and answer it—only if it is absolutely essential to take the call interrupting your presence in the meeting. Giving undivided attention to your visitors is one way of telling them you care.

From time to time there will be 'side-bar' conversations between the presenters (or your boss) and the support staff that are waiting at the back of the room. This conversation is considered private and can take place even in a local Indian language, if that is a better way to communicate.

Coffee breaks are also the best time get to know your visitors a bit by indulging in some small talk. Usually about their flight, hotel room and if they got the latest e-mail you had sent about something—anything that is light, pleasant, ice-breaking and fits the definition of 'small talk' (see Chapter 35).

In the olden, glory days of business meetings, business lunches used to be the highlight of such gatherings, with a lavish spread and ceremonious proceedings. But these days, like many other aspects of business, the glamorous and elaborate luncheons have given way to simple, convenient, 'functional' meals. In fact, it is not uncommon for the meetings to go on while the food is being consumed.

Ceremonial or simple, here are a few pointers about food. Greasy, messy, spicy food and meats which probably require a sledge hammer to break are best avoided even though it may be tempting, given that somebody else is footing the bill. Food that can be conveniently eaten with a fork or held in hand (such as sandwiches) is ideal. It might take some practice, but you should learn to eat and talk (although not with your full mouth)—exactly the opposite of what your mother taught you. If you have a break in the proceedings for lunch, make simple, non-business, non-controversial, light and humorous conversation with your visitors. If your big bosses are at the table, let them do most of the talking. Butt in only as appropriate and that too, keep it short. If you are the prime host to your foreign guests, you will have the burden of keeping the conversation going.

During coffee breaks and lunch, one common pattern found is that all the Indian team hangs out together and chit-chatting (needless to say in the local language!), while the American visitors are haplessly looking over their shoulders and trying to make sense of what is happening. A golden rule is to let the social butterfly of your group lead the charge and draw the visitors in and help in the mingling process.

A frequent complaint is that there are too many people at the Indian site purporting to be on the project. ('Are they all billable?') Lunch is a good time to explain people's functionality and role in the project. It is also proper to allow a fifteen-minute 'settling time' after lunch, during which you can help your guests check their e-mail or make phone calls or generally relax.

From time to time, your clients might try to unleash their god-given (at least the management gods) right to client-ness and act difficult. They may find faults with anything you say, express utter disgust and dissatisfaction with all of your work and above all, might display fireworks just to get your upper management's attention. While such battles are best left to the senior management, there are a few things the foot soldiers can do. First, don't take it personally and become very sensitive. Treat it as a legitimate customer complaint and deal with it professionally. Gather all the resources necessary to resolve their problems. Remember that some of them would want the heaven and the earth and that too, for one third the price your business managers are charging them at present. Don't over promise or give away things which are not in the deal.

34.4 GETTING TO CONCLUSIONS AND AGREEMENTS

With every successive hour the meeting goes on, fatigue and boredom might set in, giving way to sloppiness and wandering attention. It is important to stay alert and on top of the situation. Lack of stamina for a full day of meetings might make you particularly vulnerable to a bad deal in any negotiation. All kinds of psychological games may be played by both sides and through it all, a clear consensus should somehow emerge.

The last part of the meeting will usually be all negotiation, re-negotiation, status assessment, mid-course correction of the project and so on. Discussions, (sometimes heated) will give rise to new deliverables, new deadlines or new price tags. Negotiations on sensitive matters are best left with those who have the corporate power to make deals—usually the senior executives. Play a faithful employee by being present in the office and being around your boss, even during off-hours.

The *modus operandi* these days is that you don't sign the final deal right at the end of the client visit, but drag it on some more and dot the 'i's and cross the 't's afterwards, perhaps with your legal team poring over the clauses. Even as your guests leave, you may be left with the feeling that you could have done something better, pulled some other stops or been one day ahead to complete an important activity in your project.

34.5 POST-MEETING REVIEW

Meticulous notes-taking is absolutely crucial. There should be a designated person to generate the minutes of the meeting, which should be promptly mailed out to all the necessary people in the project after the event (this has also been covered in Chapter 24). A clear-cut list of action items generated in the meeting must be ratified by both sides and be adhered to when moving forward.

It is also a good idea to walk up to your boss a few days after the meeting and ask him what he thought of your performance during the meeting.

The sweet smell of success comes when everyone in the office walks around with the triumphant after-glow of the meeting. This is when the upper management feels it has cut a nice deal with the foreign visitors and congratulates you on a job well-done. And then you feel even more congenial toward your teammates whose chemistry made it all possible. It is even more wonderful if Mr. Smith, on his plane-ride home, feels the same high about having signed a 'win-win' deal with you and vaguely contemplates giving some more business to you. And what would make it even sweeter is if he actually managed to sneak to Agra over the weekend with his wife and saw the Taj Mahal in all its glory.

34.6 CULTURAL ISSUES

People in India sometimes tend to mollicoddle the foreign business guests and even overwhelm them by going that extra mile or by being around them all the time. There is also the romantic view of the foreign business partners as simple, benevolent souls, who have a thirst for Indian culture and Indian history. It should be understood that their basic purpose of visit is to transact business and some of them may not take to India as some others. Don't be too surprised if a foreign guest declines your invitation to go to a Bharatnatyam performance, preferring instead to spend the evening alone in the hotel gymnasium or simply hangs around his or her hotel room reading a novel or staying in touch with their home office. The Westerners jealously guard their personal 'space' and privacy (see Chapter 36). So don't foist yourselves on them or have the urge to entertain them every waking minute of their stay.



Even when they are traveling, the foreign delegation always makes an effort to stay in touch with their home office.

Fig. 34.2

Avoid disturbing the visitors in their hotel. If you have to visit them at the hotel, call them first and when you visit the hotel, call them from the lobby. Don't just go ahead and knock on their door.

Finally, a word about gift-giving during business meetings. It is rarely encouraged in the American culture and if you must give mementos to your esteemed visitors, make sure the monetary value of the gifts is not very high. Personalized stationery, small handicrafts with personalized engravings would be sufficient, although not giving any gift to the visitors is perfectly okay. Also, go easy on all the ritualistic carryings-ons—like garlanding the visitors or applying a *bindi* on them. Simple courtesies are usually enough instead of elaborate ceremonies.

34.7 IN SUMMARY

We conclude this chapter with a quick recap of the do's and don'ts when a foreign visitor visits your office.

Do:

- ▶ Do enough homework. Collect all pertinent data, organize them and analyse data along various possibilities. Keep a copy for your record.
- ▶ Prepare a detailed agenda, but be prepared for the agenda to change on the fly during the visit.
- ▶ Know who the visitors are going to be and if needed get the agenda reviewed by them.
- ▶ Make sure the right people are available, if required for any specific information that the visitor may want.
- ▶ Keep all the infrastructure in perfect working order.
- ▶ Present your talk in a slow, neutral accent. If your accent confuses the visitors, repeat yourself, perhaps using another sentence structure. Ask them to repeat if you don't understand their accent.
- ▶ Know your place in the hierarchy and play accordingly.
- ▶ Dress and behave conservatively.
- ▶ Try to lighten up situations, make small talk and be humorous.
- ▶ Follow through on the action items from the visit.

Don't

- ▶ Steal other people's presentation material or speak out of turn.
- ▶ Suffocate your guests with your kindness.
- ▶ Discuss controversial topics like politics, personal life or religion.
- ▶ Talk about company politics—yours or theirs.
- ▶ And finally, don't openly ask them about employment in their country.